

STUDENT VISA IN USA

Overview

Generally, foreign nationals who wish to travel to the United States must first obtain a visa, either a nonimmigrant visa for a temporary stay, or an immigrant visa for permanent residence. You must have a student visa to travel to the United States to study. Your course of study and the type of school you plan to attend determine whether you need an F visa or an M visa.

To enter the United States to attend:	You need the following visa category:
University or college	F
High School	
Private elementary school	
Seminary	
Conservatory	
Another academic institution, including a language training program	
Vocational or other recognized nonacademic institution, other than a language training program	M

Student Acceptance at a SEVP Approved School

The first step to studying in the United States is apply to a SEVP-approved school in the United States. If the SEVP-approved school accepts your enrollment, you will be registered for the [Student and Exchange Visitor Information System \(SEVIS\)](#) and must pay the SEVIS I-901 fee. The SEVP-approved school will issue you a Form I-20. After you receive the Form I-20 and register in SEVIS, you may apply at a U.S. Embassy or Consulate for a student (F or M) visa. You must present the Form I-20 to the consular officer when you attend your visa interview.

If your spouse and/or children will live with you in the United States while you study, they must also enroll in SEVIS, obtain individual Form I-20s from the SEVP-approved school, and apply for a visa (but they do not pay the SEVIS fee).

Visit the U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) [Student and Exchange Visitor Program \(SEVP\)](#) website to learn more about SEVIS and the SEVIS I-901 Fee.

Visit the Department of State [EducationUSA](#) website to learn about educational opportunities for undergraduate and graduate study, and an overview of the application process. You can also visit the DHS [Study in the States](#) school search page to search for SEVP-certified schools.

Eligibility Requirements

A. Applicant Eligibility

To be eligible for F-1 or M-1 status, aliens must meet the following requirements:

- Be bona fide students qualified to pursue a full course of study.
- Seek to enter the United States temporarily and solely for the purpose of pursuing such a course of study at an institution the U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) Student and Exchange Visitor Program (SEVP) has certified to admit nonimmigrant students;
- Have a foreign residence, which they have no intention of abandoning.
- Have a Certificate of Eligibility for Nonimmigrant Student Status (Form I-20) issued in their name by a Designated School Official (DSO) of a school that SEVP has certified to admit nonimmigrant students.
- Have sufficient funds available for self-support during the entire proposed course of study.
- Provide proof that the alien has paid the Student and Exchange Visitor Information System (SEVIS) fee on Payment of Fee Remittance for Certain F, J, and M Nonimmigrants (Form I 901), if applicable.

Intent to Depart:- In order to be eligible for F-1 or M-1 classification, a student must intend to depart from the United States after their temporary period of stay (for example, upon completion of their program of study and any authorized practical training in this country or upon termination of their nonimmigrant status) and have a foreign residence that they have no intention of abandoning.

Sufficient Funds :- F-1 students must have sufficient funds to successfully study in the United States without resorting to unauthorized U.S. employment for financial support. F-1 students must provide documentary evidence that sufficient funds are, or will be, available to defray all expenses during the entire period of anticipated study.

M-1 students must establish that they have funds immediately available to them or assurances of support necessary to pay all tuition and living costs for the entire period of intended stay. Evidence of financial ability for prospective F-1 and M-1 students includes.

- Family bank statements
- Documentation from a sponsor
- Financial aid letters
- Scholarship letters
- A letter from an employer showing annual salary

How To Apply

There are several steps to apply for a visa. The order of these steps and how you complete them may vary by U.S. Embassy or Consulate. Please consult the instructions on the [embassy or consulate website](#).

Complete the Online Visa Application

- Online Nonimmigrant Visa Application, [Form DS-160](#) – [Learn more](#) about completing the [DS-160](#). You must: 1) complete the online visa application, and 2) print the application form confirmation page to bring to your interview.
- Photo –You will upload your photo while completing the online Form DS-160. Your photo must meet the [Photograph Requirements](#).

1.Schedule an Interview

Interviews are generally required for visa applicants with certain limited exceptions. Consular officers may require an interview of any visa applicant.

You should schedule an appointment for your visa interview at the [U.S. Embassy or Consulate](#) in the country where you live. You may schedule your interview at another U.S. Embassy or Consulate, but be aware that it may be more difficult to demonstrate that you qualify for a visa outside of the country where you live.

Wait times for interview appointments vary by location, season, and visa category, so you should apply for your visa early. Review the interview wait time for the location where you will apply:

New Students – Student (F and M) visas for new students can be issued up to 365 days before the start date of a course of study. However, you will not be allowed to enter the United States on your student visa more than 30 days before the start date.

Continuing Students - Student (F and M) visas for continuing students may be issued at any time, as long as the student is currently enrolled at a SEVP-approved school or institution and in SEVIS. Continuing students may enter the United States at any time before classes start.

2.Prepare for Your Interview

- Fees - Pay the non-refundable visa application fee, if you are required to pay it before your interview. If your visa is approved, you may also pay a visa issuance fee, if applicable to your nationality.

3.Gather Required Documentation

Gather and prepare the following required documents before your visa interview:

- Passport valid for travel to the United States – Your passport must be valid for at least six months beyond your period of stay in the United States (unless exempt by [country-specific agreements](#)). Each individual who needs a visa must submit a separate application, including any family members listed in your passport.
- Nonimmigrant Visa Application, [Form DS-160](#) confirmation page.
- Application fee payment receipt, if you are required to pay before your interview.
- Photo – You will upload your photo while completing the online Form DS-160. If the [photo upload fails](#), you must bring one printed photo.
- Certificate of Eligibility for Nonimmigrant (F-1) Student Status-For Academic and Language Students, Form I-20 or Certificate of Eligibility for Nonimmigrant (M-1) Student Status for Vocational Students, Form I-20 – Your school will send you a Form I-20 once they have entered your information in the SEVIS database. You and your school official must sign the Form I-20. All students must be registered in the Student and Exchange Visitor System (SEVIS). Your spouse and/or minor children, if they intend live in the United States with you, will each receive an individual Form I-20.

4.Additional Documentation May Be Required

A consular officer will interview you to determine your qualifications for a student visa, and may request additional documents, such as evidence of:

- Your academic preparation, such as:

- Transcripts, diplomas, degrees, or certificates from schools you attended; and
- Standardized test scores required by your U.S. school;
- Your intent to depart the United States upon completion of the course of study; and
- How you will pay all educational, living and travel costs.

Review the instructions for how to apply for a visa on the website of the [U.S. Embassy or Consulate](#) where you will apply.

5. Attend Your Visa Interview

A consular officer will interview you to determine whether you are qualified to receive a student visa. You must establish that you meet the requirements under U.S. law to receive a visa.

Ink-free, digital fingerprint scans are taken as part of the application process. They are usually taken during your interview, but this varies based on location.

After your visa interview, the consular officer may determine that your application requires further [administrative processing](#). The consular officer will inform you if this is required.

After the visa is approved, you may need to pay a visa issuance fee (if applicable to your nationality), and make arrangements for the return of the passport and visa to you.

6. Entering the United States

A visa does not guarantee entry into the United States. A visa only allows a foreign citizen to travel to a U.S. port-of-entry (generally an airport) and request permission to enter the United States. The Department of Homeland Security (DHS), U.S. Customs and Border Protection (CBP) officials at the port-of-entry have authority to permit or deny admission to the United States.

After you present your passport, visa, and Form I-20 at the port-of-entry, a CBP official will make this decision. Upon admission, the CBP official will provide an admission stamp or paper Form I-94, Arrival/Departure Record.

Learn about procedures for students (with F or M visas) entering the United States on the CBP website under [Arrival Procedures for Students or Exchange Visitors](#). Learn about admissions and entry requirements, restrictions about bringing food, agricultural products, and other restricted/prohibited goods, and more by reviewing the [CBP website](#).

7. Extending Your Stay

Foreign students in the United States with F visas must depart the United States within 60 days after the program end date listed on Form I-20, including any authorized practical training.

Foreign students may request an extension through U.S. Citizenship and Immigration Services (USCIS) website (see the USCIS [Extend Your Stay](#) page). Additional information to maintain student status is on the U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement SEVP website under [Maintaining Your Immigration Status While a Student or Exchange Visitor](#).

Failure to depart the United States on time will result in being [out of status](#). Under U.S. law, visas of individuals who are out of status are automatically voided ([Section 222\(g\) of the Immigration and Nationality Act](#)). Any multiple entry visa that was voided due to being out of status will not be valid for future entries into the United States.

Failure to depart the United States on time may also result in you being ineligible for visas in the future in certain cases. Review [Visa Denials](#) and [Ineligibilities and Waivers: Laws](#) to learn more.

Additional Information

- There is no guarantee you will be issued a visa. Do not make final travel plans or buy tickets until you have a visa.
- For information about working in the United States during your study, review [Students and Employment](#) and Form I-765 [Work Authorization Instructions](#) on the USCIS website.
- If you have a temporary break in your study, view the information on the SEVP website under [Do Students Returning from Temporary Absences Need New Visas?](#) If your student visa is still valid, but you are outside the United States, you should consult with your Designated School Officials.
- Spouse and children
 - Your spouse and unmarried, minor children who intend to reside with you during your study may apply for F-2 or M-2 visas. Although SEVIS fee payment is not required, your school must issue them an individual Form I-20, which is required to apply for their visas. You must provide a copy of your F-1 or M-1 visa and provide proof of relationship.
 - Your minor children are permitted to attend school in the United States while accompanying you.

- U.S. Embassies and Consulates adjudicate visa applications for same-sex spouses in the same way that we adjudicate applications for opposite sex spouses.
- A valid U.S. visa in an expired passport is still valid. Unless canceled or revoked, a visa is valid until its expiration date. If you have a valid visa in your expired passport, do not remove it from your expired passport. You may use your valid visa in your expired passport along with a new valid passport for travel and admission to the United States.